

who logs into Single User mode is deemed to know the system well enough to not make careless mistakes. Also, earlier, the server on which the root would operate would also be physically protected, usually in a separate room. So there would be no ready access to the server. Now of course, with PCs, this vulnerability could be a concern, but there is a cure. You can set Linux to prevent Single User access. Hence emergency tasks have to be carried out using a boot disk and logging in with the root password.

3.4 Managing User Accounts

If you are using Linux, you would have created at least one other account apart from the root. If your computer is used by many people, some of whose work may be confidential, you would want to create a separate user account for each one of them. So what is a user account?

An account simply distinguishes different users of the computer, just like a bank account is unique to every account holder. On the computer, every account contains the files that the associated user has.

3.4.1 Creating a new user

Most Linux distributions come with a program for creating accounts that can be accessed through the GUI. Alternatively, you can use commands to create users through the terminal. “adduser” and “useradd” are two commands that can be used to create a new user. A new user can only be created by the root login or user. When you execute the “adduser” command, you will be prompted to provide a username, password and other details. In less than a minute, you will have created a new user on your system!

To delete a user just, type in “deluser <username>” and press [Enter]. Be careful, however, as you will not be given any warning—the user is simply deleted!